CENTRE FOR STRATEGIC AND INTERNATIONAL STUDIES

POLICY BRIEF

COLLECTIVE VIOLENCE AND ITS DEEPER ISSUES IN INDONESIA:

INSIGHTS FROM THE COLLECTIVE VIOLENCE EARLY WARNING (CVEW) DATASET 2024

CSIS Indonesia

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A Policy Brief by CSIS Indonesia

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Executive Summary

- While the overall number of collective violence incidents decreased by 4%, some new provinces experienced intense incidents, and increased lethality rate.
- There is an alarming trend of decreasing intervention from non-state actors.
- Around 57 election-related incidents were recorded in 2024, with most of them occurring after the House tried to reverse the Constitutional Court decision on the regional head's minimum age.
- Identity-based incidents that could develop into a larger scale usually start with singular incidents. Communities with a prior history of conflicts and vigilantism are prone to be involved in wider conflicts. The sooner the conflict intervened, the better.

Introduction

Collective violence incidents have become a recurring phenomenon in Indonesia since the end of the New Order. These small-scale incidents have increased as the state's more oppressive and authoritarian approach to governance, which was dominant during the Order, reduced. While these incidents are less likely to become systemic violence, unmonitored collective violence incidents could develop into a risk factor for mass atrocities. Additionally, general and direct elections – which were revitalized in the Reformasi Era – could increase the number of incidents due to heightened political competition.

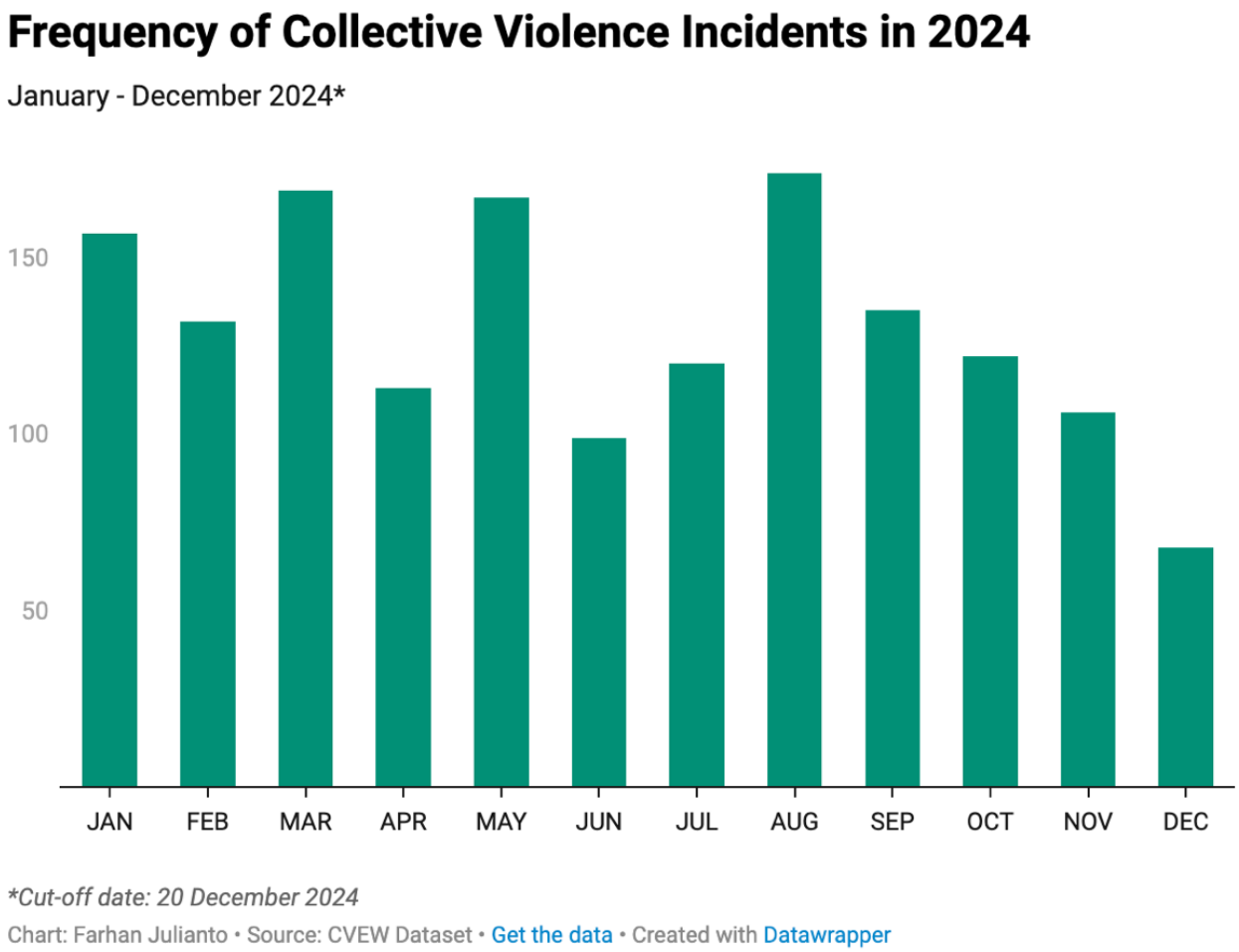
In the last four years, the Collective Violence Early Warning (CVEW) Dataset has been recording trends of collective violence incidents in Indonesia.[1] The Dataset became the only collective violence monitoring database in Indonesia after the conclusion of past efforts by state and non-state actors. The Dataset aims to provide policymakers and key stakeholders with an almost real-time insight into the trends of collective violence in Indonesia.

In this Dataset, we will present an annual trend of incident patterns in 2024. The year became an important milestone since it was the first time Indonesia held consecutive general elections, once in February for the Presidential and Legislative elections and in November for regional elections. These consecutive elections, which were part of the government's attempt at improving budget efficiency, could create a greater risk of conflict within Indonesian society.

[1] The CVEW Dataset is an initiative by the Centre for Strategic and International Studies (CSIS), with support from the Asia Pacific Centre for the Responsibility to Protect (APR2P). The Dataset can be accessed through: https://violence.csis.or.id/

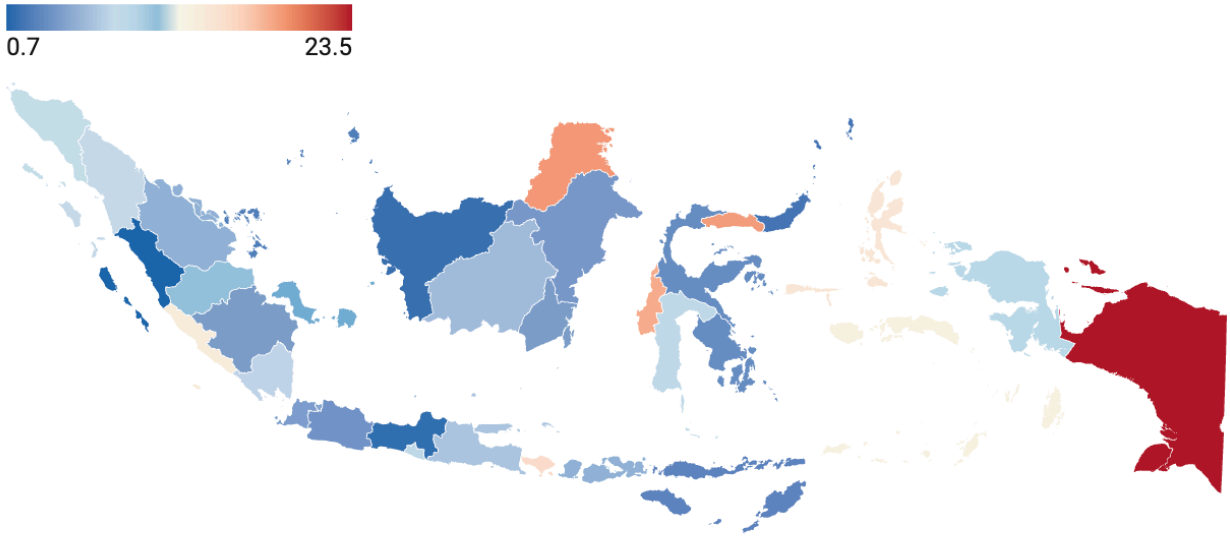
Snapshots of Collective Violence Incidents in Indonesia

Between January and December 2024, the Dataset recorded 1.562 incidents, or 4.29% decrease from 2023. This meant that there were 130 incidents monthly and 4.41 incidents daily in Indonesia. The incidents were mostly spread evenly with the timing of both elections did not affect the overall level of incidents.



In terms of geographical distribution, there were existing and new patterns compared to 2022. Similar to the trends shown in the datasets of previous years, East Java, West Java, Papua, and South Sulawesi remain in the top provinces with incidents. However, there were two new provinces that had an increasing trend of incidents, namely Lampung and Bali. Furthermore, the Dataset also provides insight into intensity. Intensity is measured by comparing the number of incidents per million population. Papua became the province with the most intensity, with 23 incidents per one million population, following a similar pattern to the 2022 findings. An interesting pattern can be seen in South Sulawesi and Bali. Both provinces experienced increasing trends of incidents in 2024. For Bali, it is the first time for the tourism-centered province to even enter the top 5.

The Intensity of Collective Violence Incidents in 2024



Intensity: Frequency of incidents per one million population

Map: Farhan Julianto • Source: CVEW Dataset • Get the data • Created with Datawrapper

Collective violence incidents in Indonesia were predominantly caused by vigilantism, with 656 incidents recorded. It became the most common issue because it covered several different acts, such as unlawful raids and acts of revenge. Vigilantism was followed by criminal issues and identity issues, with 397 and 250 incidents, respectively. Furthermore, 57 incidents were related to political issues and elections. We found that most of the election-related incidents were caused by the House of Representatives' efforts to cancel the Supreme Court ruling. This will be further discussed in the next part.

Collective violence incidents have had a steady lethality and injury rate in the last four years. In 2024, 1.515 people were injured, and 315 people lost their lives as a result of collective violence incidents. The lethality rate is higher than in 2023 although the number of casualties per incident tends to spread out more than before, with most incidents resulting in death occurring in Papua due to violent incidents between separatist groups and the military or law enforcement authorities. Meanwhile, the incident with most injuries also occurred in Papua due to election-related violence in February.

One of the efforts to reduce casualties is by intervening in ongoing incidents to de-escalate the situation. This effort is defined as intervention to be carried out by state and non-state actors. Usually, interventions taken by both state actors and non-state actors have had the best success rate to de-escalate the tension. However, findings from 2024 were different. In that year, 371, or around 23.75%, incidents were intervened. From those figures, 44.47% of interventions were deemed as successful interventions. In terms

of intervening actors, state actors (usually the local police) have the best success rate with 49%. It was followed by the combination of state and non-state actors with 47.36%.

Deeper issues behind election-related violence incidents

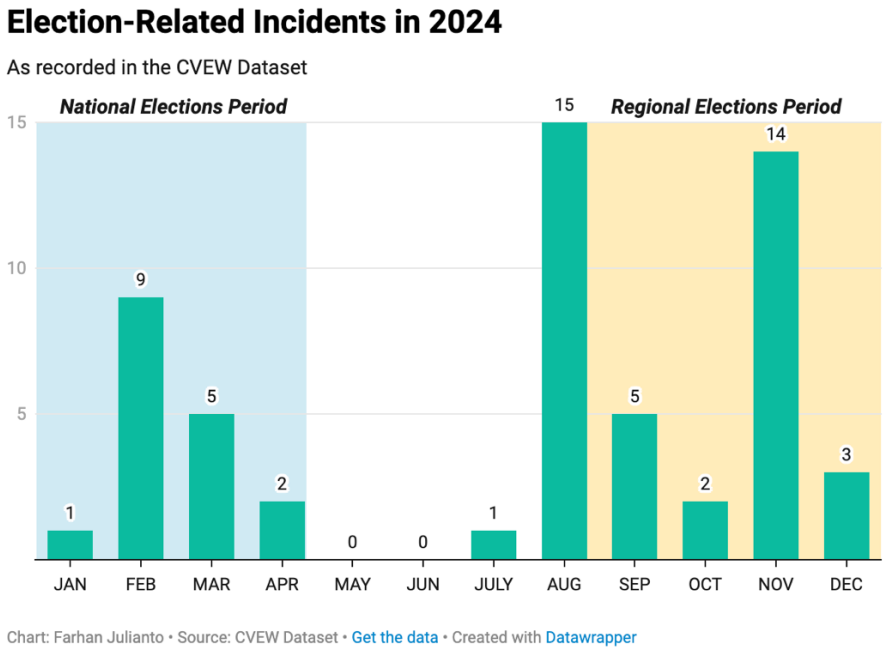
Election-related incidents became one of the prominent issues, especially after the deadly political clashes after the 2019 general election. At that time, heightened political tensions led to divisions within society and clashes among supporters of political candidates, particularly the presidential candidates of the time. Those clashes culminated in a riot in front of the General Election Supervisory Agency, which resulted in 6 deaths and more than 200 injuries.[2]

However, those patterns did not reemerge in the 2024 general election. According to the Dataset, 57 election-related violence incidents were recorded throughout the year. While those numbers were relatively low compared to the overall incidents, it is important to acknowledge the limitations of the Dataset in identifying underlying issues of incidents that were committed by unknown actors.

Patterns of incidents in the 2024 election were predominantly influenced by the timing and socio-political context surrounding the incidents. The biggest factor that provoked incidents across the country was the House of Representatives effort to reverse the Constitutional Court ruling by revising the election bill in one night.[3] Just one day after the revision was brought to the House's General Assembly, riots and protests emerged in at least 10 provinces across Indonesia, with some of them resulting in violent incidents. Riots and protests in front of the House building, specifically, were recorded as 5 different incidents in a single string.

[2] Karina M. Tehusijarana, "Who was behind Jakarta riots?" *The Jakarta Post*, 29 May 2019, https://www.thejakartapost.com/news/2019/05/28/who-was-behind-jakarta-riots.html

[3] The Constitutional Court ruled the regional head candidates' age limitation on August 21st. Meanwhile, the House rejected the Constitutional Court decision and chose to revise the law on minimum age to cancel the Court's decision. For further information, see: Eka Yudha Saputra, "House Rejects Constitutional Court Decision on Regional Candidate's Age Limitation," *Tempo*, 21 August 2024, https://en.tempo.co/read/1906724/house-rejects-constitutional-court-decision-on-regional-candidates-age-limitation



Another pattern of the incidents during the election period was violence against on-duty field officers from the election committee, supervisory agency, and local committees. This was especially apparent during the regional elections, where there were more incidents compared to the national election.

However, most injuries and deaths came from conflicts during the national elections, especially in relation to legislative elections. Moreover, the two incidents with the most casualties both occurred in Papua. Incidents with the most injuries (62 cases) occurred in Nduga during clashes between supporters of legislative candidates in Papua regarding the distribution of votes by the Noken system.[4] The Noken system was also 'responsible' for the incident with the most deaths (2), which occurred during clashes between tribes over voting distribution for legislative candidates.

Election-related incidents were not merely singular incidents without structural causes. The incidents described above show that violence reflects deeper issues within Indonesian society. Clashes and riots to defend the Constitutional Court ruling, for instance, became a resonating issue due to the previous disappointments towards government institutions during the presidential election. Meanwhile, clashes in Papua were triggered by the Noken system, which limits individuals to cast their votes based on their preferences. Moreover, the Noken system also exposed the vulnerability of the District Chief, as seen in the case of Nduga.

[4] Noken system is a traditional practice to vote in Papua. Within the system, voting is carried out by communities, either through deliberation or through the delegation of votes to the district/village leader. The system is an approved concept by the Constitutional Court. The Noken system has been abandoned in the Papua province but still adopted in the newly-formed provinces.

Identity-based incidents *vis-à-vis* vigilantism issues

Identity-based incidents require further scrutiny due to their capability to trigger bigger atrocities. In 2024, identity-based incidents were the third-most reported incidents under vigilantism and criminality issues. Nonetheless, while the numbers may be incredibly high, the predominant reported cases were clashes among students or community groups (but not necessarily related to religious or ethnic groups) and were singular or one-off incidents.

However, there were interesting incidents that can be further observed, which was the hostility against Rohingya refugees in Aceh. Due to the years of unlawful persecution and abuse in Myanmar, Rohingya refugees fled to other countries that were reachable by land or by sea. Since late 2023, Indonesia has been facing waves of Rohingya refugees, most of which landed in Aceh. Unfortunately, those refugees were being resisted and threatened by the local community due to perceptions that the refugees were perceived as not respecting the norms and principles adhered to by the Acehnese community.

This trend continued in 2024. There were at least four reported incidents related to the exclusion of Rohingya refugees, and all four of them resulted in vigilantism and persecution of those refugees. All four of the incidents occurred in Aceh and involved some local actors like villagers and students. The biggest of those incidents, in terms of the number of actors involved, was the expulsion in Syiah Kuala, Aceh. We must also point out that this resistance and expulsion is also a governance issue. Neither the Aceh Government nor the Indonesian Government have clarified their policy on Rohingya refugees and how – or even where – to shelter them.[5]

Second, clashes among tribes. Clashes among tribes are concerning due to the risk of mass mobilization that could result in bigger incidents. There were two incidents that could be examined further. The first incident is clashes between the Moni and Mee tribes in Papua. These tribes have a history of violent fighting over territory, which has resulted in casualties and exclusions. In 2024, the clashes resurfaced in April, where acts of harassment and abuse were met with arson between the two tribes.

The second incident, with an almost similar pattern, is a conflict between Pesaku and Rarampadende villagers in Central Sulawesi. Both villages also have a history of conflict. The incident was triggered by an assault on two Pesaku villagers in Rarampadende territory and one Rarampende village in Pesaku territory. Both assaults were later ruled

[5] "APHR Urges Indonesia to Act Swiftly to Protect Stranded Rohingya Refugees," *ASEAN Parliamentarians for Human Rights*, 25 October 2024, https://aseanmp.org/publications/post/aphr-urges-indonesia-to-act-swiftly-to-protect-stranded-rohingya-refugees/

as assaults by unknown assailants, but unfortunately did not prevent further escalation between the two villages.

One takeaway from both incidents is that patterns of identity-based incidents could escalate and result in more victims. *First*, it usually starts with a single criminal incident or assault by unknown assailants but then triggers suspicion among the conflicting groups. *Second*, conflicts are more prone to communities that have a history of conflicts. *Third*, mass mobilization and vigilantism tend to lead to wider conflicts that could result in higher casualties. These three patterns were also present in previous years, and the sooner the conflict can be intervened, the better.

Recommendations

Based on the findings mentioned, we recommend the following policy approaches:

1. **Enhancing intervention mechanisms by engaging non-state actors effectively**

   While state actors were already involved in intervention, their response time may not always be sufficient to prevent escalation. Engaging non-state actors like capable community leaders, district leaders, religious leaders, and others might complement the state by providing rapid responses. Therefore, the government – especially the local government – needs to empower local community groups by improving their conflict de-escalation, first aid, and reporting capabilities.

2. **Improving regulatory impact assessment within the legislative process**

   Poorly assessed legislation often results in collective violence incidents. To contain the impact of all regulatory measures, the parliament should consider mandating pre-legislation impact reviews to ensure that all legislation undergo a thorough impact assessment, focusing on social, economic, and environmental implications. Moreover, the presence of regulatory impact assessment also prevents the parliament from passing non-transparent legislation.

3. **Anticipating new forms of violence through proactive monitoring and awareness**

   Some forms of violence have been recorded in the Dataset, although the frequency and patterns were still not enough to develop into mass atrocities. For instance, there has been an increase in sexual violence-related incidents, especially in South Sulawesi. Furthermore, criminality, as the second-largest issue, continues to grow. Moreover, violent incidents reflect the evolving nature of societal challenges, and therefore, enhancing awareness and preventive measures is a must within society.

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